

Seminar 3 — Mapping an Advocacy Coalition

IR227 Politics of Change — TA slides (draft, editable)

July 2026

What you'll do in 90 minutes

[Bridge to seminar] *Map the advocacy coalitions in your assigned case. Identify their three-tier belief systems. Name the broker if there is one. Explain why change has happened (or hasn't) over the past decade. Then a brief reflection: does ACF fit cleanly, or would PET or MSF do better?*

- Six cases, three pairs.
- Each group: 3–4 students, one case.
- Coalition mapping, change/stability analysis, drafting + reflection, plenary.

Three methodological points up front

1. A coalition is not an individual. It's a collective with shared policy-core beliefs, persistent over time.
2. The three tiers are analytically distinct. Don't collapse them.
3. The framework reflection is the seminar's payoff. Defend it with named concepts.

Six cases, three pairs

Pair	Case A	Case B
Climate ACFs	Brazil (confrontational)	China (cooperative)
Regulatory politics	EU pharma DTCA-PD	China birth-control 1980–2015
Cash transfers	Brazil's <i>Bolsa Família</i>	Mexico's <i>Oportunidades</i>

Within each pair: same archetype, different strategy / political system / coalition pathway. (Nohrstedt et al. 2023; OECD 2025)

Recap: the three-tier belief structure

Framework: ACF beliefs

Deep core Fundamental normative commitments. Liberty vs equality, role of government.

Policy core Positions on the proper scope of government in this domain. Causal understandings within the domain.

Secondary aspects Implementation details. Which agency, which standards, what budget.

Coalitions form around shared *policy core* beliefs. (Nohrstedt et al. 2023)

Recap: the four pathways to change

1. External shocks (elections, crises, demographic shifts).
2. Internal shocks (scientific findings, technological discontinuities).
3. Negotiated agreements (rare; require hurting stalemates and brokers).
4. Accumulated evidence (slow; via professional forums).

Each predicts different observable conditions before, during, and after change.

Recap: policy brokers

- Mediators between coalitions, not advocates.
- Often institutionally located (senior civil servants, certain judges, intergovernmental staff).
- Distinct from policy entrepreneurs — brokers don't push a position.
- Authority depends on perceived neutrality.

Negotiated agreements need brokers. So do many learning episodes. (Nohrstedt et al. 2023)

Worked example: Brazil's confrontational climate ACF

- **Coalitions.** Pro-climate (NGOs + Itamaraty + São Paulo + USP/UNICAMP/INPA) vs. developmentalist (agribusiness + Mines and Energy + ruralist Congress + BNDES segments).
- **Three tiers.** Deep core: internationalist-environmentalist vs. developmentalist-nationalist. Policy core: climate as compatible with national interest vs. external constraint. Secondary: deforestation monitoring, biofuels, Amazon Fund.
- **Broker.** Limited; presidential office at moments (Lula's environment ministers).
- **Pathway.** External shocks (Copenhagen 2009, Paris 2015) plus accumulated evidence.
- **Aamodt's mode.** Confrontational — federal democracy with electoral alternation rewards public coalitional opposition. (Aamodt and Stensdal 2017; Nohrstedt et al. 2023)

Worked example: EU pharma DTCA-PD — control of governmental units

- **Coalitions.** Anti (member-state health ministries + consumer NGOs + European Public Health Alliance + generic pharma + health MEPs) vs. pro (EFPIA innovator firms + DG ENTR/GROW + industry-funded patient orgs).
- **Three tiers.** Deep: precautionary-collective vs. liberal-information-access. Policy: prescription-drug advertising direct to consumers as incompatible with rational health-system management vs. compatible if regulated. Secondary: standards, enforcement, transitions.
- **Pathway.** Anti-coalition success via *control of governmental units* (multi-level competence: member-state treaty authority + Commission procedural role) rather than resource superiority. (Brooks 2018)
- **Verdict.** Pro-DTCA-PD attempts have repeatedly failed. EU's multi-level structure is the decisive variable.

Worked example: Mexico's Oportunidades — evidence-first coalition

- **Coalition.** Human-capital coalition: PRI- and PAN-aligned economists in SEDESOL/Bienestar + World Bank Mexico-economist network + PROGRESA evaluation team.
- **Three tiers.** Deep: liberal-developmental with strong state capacity. Policy: conditional cash transfers tied to schooling and health as the route to poverty reduction. Secondary: conditionality strictness, transfer level, targeting design.
- **Pathway.** Accumulated evidence (PROGRESA's 1997–2000 randomised evaluation) plus elite cross-party consensus.
- **Strategy contrast.** Mexico built credibility via evidence first; Brazil's Bolsa Família coalition built it via political alignment first. Same outcome, different pathway entry. (Tomazini 2019)

Phase 1 — coalition mapping (20 min)

1. Identify the major coalitions (typically 2–3).
2. For each, name members or kinds of members.
3. Map their beliefs at all three tiers (deep core / policy core / secondary aspects).
4. Name a policy broker if one is visible.

Output: a sentence per coalition you can defend with evidence.

Phase 2 — change / stability analysis (20 min)

1. Has the case produced change in the past decade, or stability?
2. If change: through which of the four pathways?
3. If stability: what's keeping it stable? Which pathway is *not* operating, and why?
4. Identify the binding constraint for further change.

Output: a verdict on change/stability, defended with one of the four pathways.

Phase 3 — drafting + reflection (15 min)

Case: The diagnostic memo

- One paragraph: the ACF map. Coalitions, beliefs, broker, change pathway, verdict.
- Two-to-three sentences: framework reflection. Does ACF fit cleanly, or would PET (subsystem politics + venue shopping) or MSF (streams + coupling) do better?

Be specific. “ACF fits” is not a defensible answer; “ACF fits because of X, but PET would catch Y better” is.

Phase 4 — plenary (25 min)

Within each pair: one group presents the ACF map. The other group adds the contrasting point.

- Climate: Brazil vs. China — same archetype, opposite strategies. Why?
- Regulation: EU pharma vs. China birth control — same archetype, different political systems. Why?
- Cash transfers: Brazil vs. Mexico — same archetype, similar outcomes via different strategies. Why?

Then: cross-cutting framework reflection. Where did ACF win? Where did another framework do better?

Three things to take away

1. ACF works when the three tiers stay distinct. Collapsing them is the most common failure mode.
2. Coalition strategy is contingent on opportunity structure. Same beliefs can produce different tactics in different systems.
3. The framework-fit question matters. Choosing the right framework for the question is itself an analytical skill.

Tomorrow: from *when change is possible* to *how change can be steered*.

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